

PHISHING AWARENESS ANALYSIS

DecodeLabs Cyber Security Internship

Project 3

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1. Introduction

Phishing is a cyber attack that attempts to trick users into revealing sensitive information such as usernames, passwords, banking details, or OTPs. Attackers often use deceptive emails, messages, or websites that appear legitimate. This report analyzes a phishing email sample, identifies red flags, and explains why the message is unsafe.

2. Sample Phishing Email

Subject: Congratulations! You Have Won a Free Smartphone

Dear Winner,

Congratulations! You have been selected to receive a brand-new smartphone absolutely free.

To claim your prize, click the link below and provide your personal details:

<http://free-smartphone-giveaway.com>

This offer expires in 12 hours.

Best Regards,

Promotional Team

3. Red Flag Analysis

Red Flag 1: Too Good to Be True Offer

The email promises a free smartphone, which is a common tactic used to attract victims.

Red Flag 2: Suspicious Link

The URL does not belong to a trusted company or official brand website.

Red Flag 3: Urgency

The offer expires in 12 hours, creating pressure to act quickly.

Red Flag 4: Request for Personal Information

Users are asked to provide personal details to claim the prize.

Red Flag 5: Unknown Sender

The sender identity is unclear and cannot be verified.

4. Suspicious Keywords Identified

The following keywords and phrases indicate possible phishing activity:

- Congratulations
- Free Smartphone
- Claim Your Prize
- Limited Time Offer
- Expires in 12 Hours
- Provide Personal Details

These phrases are commonly used in phishing campaigns to create fear and urgency.

5. Why the Message is Unsafe

This message is unsafe because it uses a fake reward to attract victims and trick them into sharing personal information. Such phishing attacks often lead to identity theft, financial fraud, or credential compromise.

6. Safety Recommendations

- Be cautious of emails offering prizes, rewards, or giveaways that seem too good to be true.
- Verify the legitimacy of promotions through official company websites.
- Avoid clicking links from unknown or untrusted senders.
- Never share personal, banking, or login information through email links.
- Check website URLs carefully before entering any information.
- Enable Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA) on important accounts.
- Report suspicious emails to the appropriate security team or email provider.

7. Conclusion

The phishing email analyzed in this report contains several warning signs, including suspicious links, urgent language, generic greetings, and fear-based messaging. Identifying these indicators can help users avoid phishing attacks and protect

sensitive information. Security awareness remains one of the most effective defenses against phishing threats.